Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) or South Punjab still exists, where their foot soldiers are recruited either through tribal alliances or through madrassas. But there is an increasing recognition of individuals educated in elite schools or universities taking up the terrorist cause.

Military generals and politicians in the past have pushed narratives through policy agendas – whether it was Ayub Khan's modernization project, Z. A. Bhutto's Islamic socialism, Zia-ul-Haq's Islamization or Pervez Musharraf's Enlightened Moderation – but this 'national narrative' is different. It is being implemented through a counterterrorism authority, the National Counter Terrorism Authority (NACTA), revealing the extent to which the entire national discourse in Pakistan has been securitized. There is a recognition that individuals and communities who are supporting these terrorist causes are being fed a different narrative they have chosen to believe, whether premised on a (mis)interpretation of Islam, or one which questions the legitimacy of a state that has failed to deliver basic services to its citizens – a narrative that needs to be countered not just through traditional counterterrorism means, but also ideologically. In this process, NACTA tried to co-opt universities from across the country to support and promote the national narrative. However, these counterterrorism efforts have increasingly reinforced the emergence of a modern Pakistani 'security state' that recognizes the importance of public opinion in order to defeat these various threats, where any individual or institutional challenge to the security state's 'national narrative' is considered an obstacle in its fight against extremism, sectarianism, terrorism and militancy. If this means clamping down on an individual's freedom to critique or voice opposition to the security state – as evident in the case of bloggers, journalists, students or academics who have been picked up by security agencies and disciplined to follow the state narrative, or even educational institutions that have been urged (if not bullied) into self-censorship – in Pakistan post 9/11, the nexus between security agencies and state institutions has been further strengthened, increasingly weakening an already fallible social contract.

The security state approach has led counterintuitively to the state going after those who are seen as possibly critiquing Islam. An example of this is the Pakistan Telecommunication Authority (PTA) sending a message on all Pakistani mobile phones in 2017 asking users to report anyone who might be committing blasphemy. Also problematic and in the same line of thinking as the monitoring of anti-Islamic discourse on social media is the oxymoronic stance of the security state to mainstream right-wing religious parties into Pakistani politics in an attempt to control their power. The Milli Muslim League, a political